ABOUT 90 MINUTES

What Is Stoicism?

What would it mean to live well, whatever happens to you?

READING · 10 MINUTES

Stoicism 101. Give a short talk in your own words, drawing on Stoicism 101, or watch this five-minute video together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 15	Read · 10	Discuss · 40	Practice · 10	Close · 15
Ground rules; names and what brought you	Your short talk or the video	The questions below	Introduce it	Agree on a regular day and time

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Before tonight, what did you think “stoic” meant? What surprised you?
2. The Stoics said a good life depends on character, not circumstances. Do you believe that?
3. Think of someone you admire for how they handle hardship. What do they actually do?
4. Wisdom, courage, justice, temperance: which comes easiest to you? Which is hardest?
5. What would make a group like this worth your time each month?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Evening review. Each night, ask: What went well? What didn’t? What will I do differently tomorrow?

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“What do you mean by…?” When someone says *good* or *happy*, ask them to define it first.

NOTES

After: post a short recap on your Substack

MONTH 2 OF 12

ABOUT 90 MINUTES

What's in My Control?

Why do we spend so much energy on things we can't change?

READING · ONE PAGE

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1. Some things are up to us: our judgments, intentions, and actions. Others aren't: our bodies, reputations, and other people.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Try it on a real worry	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. List what worried you this week. Which items were fully up to you?
2. Is your health in your control? Your job? Where exactly is the line?
3. If outcomes aren't up to us, why try at all?
4. What changes when you aim at your effort rather than the result?
5. Where could this idea go wrong if it's taken too far?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Mine / not mine. Once a day, split a worry into the part that's yours and the part that isn't. Act only on yours.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" When someone says something is out of their control, ask how they'd tell.

NOTES

ABOUT 90 MINUTES

Anger

Is it the thing that happened, or what I tell myself about it?

READING · ONE PARAGRAPH

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 5. We aren't disturbed by things themselves, but by our judgments about them. Optional: a page from Seneca's *On Anger*.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask people to notice one moment of irritation during the week.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Rewrite one judgment	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Recall a recent moment of anger. What happened, and what did you tell yourself about it?
2. Seneca thought anger is never useful. Do you agree?
3. What's the difference between anger and a firm, fair response?
4. What would a pause change: counting, walking away, sleeping on it?
5. When you're angry, who is harmed most?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Name the judgment. When you're annoyed, finish the sentence "I'm telling myself that…" Then ask whether it's true.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Talk about anger stays vague until someone describes a real moment.

NOTES

MONTH 4 OF 12

ABOUT 90 MINUTES

Worry About the Future

Do we suffer more from what happens, or from what we imagine?

READING · TWO PAGES

Seneca, Letter 13 (“On Groundless Fears”). Many fears never arrive; Seneca asks whether a feared evil is certain before we suffer it.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Link the letter; reading it ahead is optional.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Five quiet minutes	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What future event takes up the most room in your head right now?
2. Think of past worries. How many happened the way you feared?
3. Seneca asks whether the evil is certain. Is that comforting, or dismissive?
4. What’s the difference between planning and worrying?
5. How could calmly imagining the worst help rather than hurt?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Rehearse a setback. For five minutes, calmly picture something going wrong, and plan how you’d respond well.

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“If that’s true, what follows?” Walk a worry forward, step by step, to see where it really leads.

NOTES

Difficult People

How do I stay decent toward people who make it hard?

READING · ONE PARAGRAPH

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 2.1. Each morning he expects to meet rude, ungrateful people, reminds himself they act from ignorance, and that we're made to work together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Remind people to keep examples anonymous: no names, no workplaces.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; keep it anonymous	Aloud, twice	The questions below	Write your own 2.1	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Marcus expects difficult people every morning. Is that pessimistic or practical?
2. Think of someone who frustrates you. What might they believe that makes their behavior make sense to them?
3. Does understanding someone mean excusing them?
4. In that relationship, what is actually in your control?
5. What does justice ask of you toward people you don't like?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Morning preparation. Before work, say your own version of 2.1: who you might meet today, and how you want to treat them.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that always true?" When someone says "people like that never change," invite a counterexample.

NOTES

ABOUT 90 MINUTES

What's Actually Good?

If money, health, and reputation aren't the goal, what is?

READING · THREE PAGES

Plato, *Euthydemus* 278e–282e. Socrates argues that wealth and health only benefit us when they're used wisely, so wisdom is what makes anything good.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	**Discuss · 45**	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	**The questions below**	Try it on a real choice	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Name three things you want most. Why do you want them?
2. Can wealth or health ever harm someone? How?
3. Socrates says wisdom is what makes other things useful. Do you agree?
4. The Stoics called money and health "preferred indifferents." What's gained and lost in that view?
5. Looking back on six meetings, what's one idea you've actually used?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

The wise-person test. Before a decision, ask: what would a wise person do here, and why?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Bring back month two: are the things you want most up to you?

NOTES